

IMPERIAL

Experimental and Computational Investigation of Small-Scale Turbopump Performance with a Novel Barske-Type Impeller



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Abstract

Your abstract goes here. Summarise the key motivations, methodology, and findings of your turbopump FYP.

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Nomenclature

A	Area (m^2)
H	Pump Head (m)
N	Rotational Speed (RPM)
P	Power (W)
Q	Volumetric Flow Rate (m^3/s)
η	Efficiency ($-$)
ρ	Density (kg/m^3)
ω	Angular Velocity (rad/s)

Abbreviations

CFD	Computational Fluid Dynamics
FYP	Final Year Project
NPSH _a	Net Positive Suction Head Available
NPSH _r	Net Positive Suction Head Required

1 Introduction

Rocket engines require high pressures to operate efficiently. Small scale liquid propulsion such as satellite propulsion and amateur liquid rocket propulsion runs almost entirely on pressure fed feed systems due to their simplicity and reliability. Larger orbital rockets use turbopumps because the mass of the required tanks becomes prohibitive. However, as space launch becomes exponentially more accessible, there is a growing interest in small scale rocket propulsion systems. For example, lunar landers, satellite propulsion and amateur liquid rockets are seeing a resurgence in interest. Due to the historical focus on large turbopumps for such applications, turbopumps at the smaller scale are not as well documented and have different design considerations. A turbopump is a pump and the turbine that drives it, and both are punished by the small scale.

1.1 Small scale rocket pump challenges

Pump driven propulsion is the solution orbital liquid rockets use to solve the tank mass problem. By storing propellents at lower pressures and pumping them to the required pressures allows for a large reduction in tank mass. The pump is usually driven by turbines powered by burning a portion of the propellents, or by the heat generated by the cooling of the engine. In recent years, battery and electric pump technology has advanced to such a point that for smaller rockets such as the Electron rocket by Rocket Lab [?], electric pumps are starting to become a more viable alternative to turbine driven pumps.

Pumps are generally characterized by their flow rate Q_{opt} , the head H_{opt} and rotor speed n [?]. These three parameters largely decide the pump geometry and type of pump. These three parameters can be related by a quantity known as specific speed, n_q , N_s or ω_s depending on the units and definitions used:

$$n_q = \frac{n\sqrt{Q}}{H^{3/4}} \quad [\text{RPM}, \text{m}^3/\text{s}, \text{m}] \quad (1)$$

Different pump geometries are optimal for different regions of specific speed as can be shown by [?]. Most liquid rocket engines operate between a specific speed n_q of 20 to 40 and utilize the centrifugal radial impeller to maximize efficiency. This works great for large rocket engines, but scaling this down to smaller engines becomes increasingly difficult. All rocket engines require high pressures, but smaller rocket engines require less flow rate. To stay in the specific speed according to eq. (1) that allows for high efficiency in the centrifugal pump requires increasing rotational speed.

To achieve the specific speed of 20 for a smaller rocket engine of around 5 kN requiring 1.0 kg/s of kerosene at 50 bar leads to rotational speeds of around 71 051 rpm. Such high rotational speeds leads to challenging mechanical design conditions. To solve this problem, a single pump can be separated into multiple stages, separating the head rise to increase the specific speed of each stage. This is a common solution to pumping hydrogen. This thesis however addresses the other solution, which is to deal with the lower specific speed.

As shown in [?], at lower specific speeds, the partial admission pump becomes the optimum efficiency pump geometry at specific speeds of 5-10. However, even though these pumps are the most efficient at these low specific speeds, they physically cannot achieve the high efficiencies of a full admission pump. This is the main limitation of trying to operate at low specific speeds.

Due to its lower efficiency and the lack of pump fed liquid rockets for small engines, there is a lack of literature, design knowledge and experimental data surrounding these pumps. This thesis aims to address this gap by reviewing existing literature, designing and manufacturing a partial admission centrifugal pump and comparing its experimental performance specifically in the use case of rocket engines.

1.2 Small scale rocket turbine challenges

On the other end of the turbopump shaft is the turbine which drives the pump. The turbine faces the same problem as the pump. If using the gas generator cycle, the small turbine leads to lower blade speeds U . To extract the maximum work from the gas, gas velocity C_0 must be high, leading to a supersonic blade turbine. The high gas velocity relative to blade speed leads to the turbine running at a lower efficiency than the optimum $U/C_0 \approx 0.5$ [?]. The smaller mass flow also cannot fill the annulus at a sensible blade height, leading to partial admission where only a fraction of the annulus has gas flowing through it at any given time. This makes the stage lossy and awkward to design. In addition to these design limitations, supersonic turbine design is far less studied than subsonic, where methods are scattered across older sources.

This thesis tackles the design of a turbopump in the context of small scale liquid rocket engines which forces both pump and turbine off optimum design conditions, then demonstrates their coupled performance in a full integration test. The thesis is framed around the design of a 20 000 rpm turbopump using water as an inert simulant for the pumped rocket propellents. Then, a supersonic partial admission impulse turbine is designed to drive the pump using compressed air as the working fluid. The two are then coupled together and tested as a single system to evaluate performance.

1.3 Aims and Objectives

The aim of this thesis is to investigate the performance of a small scale rocket low specific speed turbopump with a Barske pump and a supersonic partial admission turbine. To this end, the objectives of this thesis are:

1. Pump characterisation: Determine the head-flow curve, efficiency, and cavitation behaviour of a Barske-type impeller across operating speeds
2. Turbine design and model validation: Design a single-stage partial-admission supersonic impulse turbine with a first-principles computational toolchain, and validate those models against the achievable test data.
3. Turbopump integration: Demonstrate coupled turbopump operation at scaled off-design conditions and perform analytical extrapolation to the full 20 000 rpm gas generator regime.
4. Computational toolchain assessment: Assess the 1D/analytical design toolchain against the experimental data, and establish where analytical prediction is sufficient for this class of machine.

1.4 Scope and Limitations

This thesis covers the theory, design, manufacture and testing of a small scale turbopump system on inert propellents. The pump was tested up to 9000 rpm, significantly lower than the design speed of 20 000 rpm in the first and final iterations of the conducted experiments. This means the data validation can only happen for the off-design point and extrapolation to the design point is required. Cryogenic and hot gas design and testing are strictly outside the scope of this thesis. Operational safety procedures are included in the appendix.

1.5 Thesis Structure

Chapter 2 establishes the theoretical background: pump specific speed, Barske impeller characteristics, impulse turbine velocity triangle theory, and the relevant prior art. Chapter 3 details the pump design and sizing methodology. Chapter 4 covers turbine design, including structural analysis of the rotor at 20,000 rpm. Chapter 5 describes the custom instrumentation and data acquisition system. Chapter 6 documents the test rig and assembly. Chapter 7 presents the experimental results. Chapter 8 discusses the findings in the context of design predictions and prior literature. Chapter 9 draws conclusions and recommends future work.

2 Pump Design Theory

Pump sizing starts with determining the required flow rate and head. As the pump for this report serves to provide consistent fuel flow into the rocket injector, the flow rate and head are predetermined.

3 Conclusion

Conclusion text goes here.

References

A First Appendix Title

Appendix content goes here (e.g., calibration curves, large tables, or code).